Cambridge update

July 2026

Guy Emerson

- Part-time Assistant Professor (Dept. Theoretical and Applied Linguistics), lecturing Computational Linguistics.
- Part-time Assistant Research Professor (Dept. Computer Science and Technology), working for the Institute for Automated Language Teaching and Assessment (ALTA).
- Applying for funding for ongoing work on "Judicious Incoherence" (fundamental result on theoretical complexity of machine learning — see last year's talk for outline).
- Returning from parental leave in September.

Guy’s latest project

See also podcast episode on experience of raising kids speaking Hokkien:
https://youtu.be/9eC6icskF18

Weiwei Sun

- **Using DELPH-IN resources for modelling language acquisition**
  - **ERG-based analysis of developmental language data**
    - use ERG to analyse child speech and create richly structured developmental annotations.
  - **ERS-CHILDES as the basis of a proxy task for language-production acquisition**
    - Induce a production grammar directly from MRs.
    - Publication: Gao and Sun (EMNLP 2025); Wang, Gao and Sun (CogSci 2026).
    - Two papers under review.
- **Indirectly related to DELPH-IN**
  - Universal-guided grammar induction from strings.
  - Universals: extended projection (Chomskyan); referentiality, predication, and modification as fundamental communicative functions (Functionalist); and the Final-over-Final Constraint (Chomskyan).
  - Connection: type hierarchies provide fine-grained "universal" information that should be easier to operationalise.
- **Unrelated?**
  - Phonological reconstruction.
  - Computational orthography for language revitalisation.

Ann Copestake

- Describing LLMs for general and interdisciplinary audiences — now taking a partially historical perspective.
  - Recently submitted journal paper ‘Meaning and language processing: making sense of Large Language Models’ (Copestake, Duggan, Herbelot, Moeding and von Redecker).
- History of CL, especially in Cambridge (CLRU) in late ‘50s and early ‘60s (papers of Karen Spärck Jones, Roger Needham and others).
  - Trying to highlight current gaps in theoretical understanding, lack of clarity in terminology and so on.
  - Session on ‘What makes an approach to modelling language 'symbolic'?’ later today.